Ali Pangalian Macaorao Balindong

Ali Pangalian Macaorao Balindong (January 1, 1940 – October 2, 2025) was a Filipino lawyer, statesman, and one of the most enduring voices in the long struggle for Bangsamoro self-determination.

Over a career spanning more than five decades, he served in nearly every chamber of Philippine governance: from the 1971 Constitutional Convention, to the floors of the House of Representatives, to the historic halls of the first Bangsamoro Parliament, where he served as Speaker until his death.

He was 85 years old.

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BACKGROUND

Pangalian Balindong came from a family that knew what public life meant.

He was born on January 1, 1940, in Lanao, now the barangay of Dapao in Pualas, Lanao del Sur. His father, Sultan Amer Macaorao Balindong, served as mayor of Malabang, and the family belonged to one of the influential clans of the region. His mother was Maimona Marohom. As the eldest son of that household, Pangalian carried both the weight and the opportunity that came with his lineage.

He was, by most accounts, a man who took that seriously.

A Maranao through and through, Balindong would go on to spend his adult life arguing, legislating, and negotiating on behalf of Muslim Filipinos, from courtrooms and convention halls to the very parliament his people had long fought to establish.

Atty. Ali Pangalian M. Balindong



Full Name

Ali Pangalian Macaorao Balindong

Born

January 1, 1940 Lanao (present-day Dapao, Pualas, Lanao del Sur), Philippine Commonwealth

He married Jamela Malawani Alonto on April 28, 1968. They raised eight children together.

EDUCATION

Balindong completed his primary schooling at the Malabang Central Elementary School in 1954, then moved on to Our Lady of Peace High School, finishing in 1958.

For higher education, he went to Manila and enrolled at Manuel L. Quezon University. He earned a degree in Political Science in 1962, then stayed on to pursue law, finishing his LL.B. in 1966. He passed the bar examinations the following year, in 1967.

He later pursued graduate studies in public administration at the Mindanao State University, taking up master's units that deepened his grounding in governance.

He was also a member of the Mu Kappa Phi Exclusive Law Fraternity.

CAREER

Early Legal and Constitutional Work

Before he ever held elective office, Balindong was already doing meaningful work in the political trenches.

After passing the bar, he went into private legal practice and took on a role that would define much of his early public life: legal counsel for the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF). This wasn't a peripheral position. The MNLF was at the center of the Bangsamoro struggle for self-governance, and Balindong's legal expertise was part of how that movement engaged with the Philippine state.

In 1971, he joined the Philippine Constitutional Convention as a delegate representing the Lone District of Lanao del Sur. He was just over 30 years old. It was his first formal seat at a table where the rules of the country were being written, and it wouldn't be his last.

ARMM Assemblyman and Regional Speaker

Balindong began his electoral career through the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao.

Died

October 2, 2025 (aged 85) Quezon City, Philippines

Ethnicity

Maranao

Clan

Balindong clan of Lanao del Sur

Education

B.A. Political Science, Manuel L. Quezon University (1962) LL.B., Manuel L. Quezon University (1966) Graduate units in Public Administration, Mindanao State University

Profession

Lawyer, Politician

Political Party

Independent (2016–2025) Liberal Party (2010–2016) Lakas (1995–2010)

Offices Held

Speaker, Bangsamoro Parliament (2019–2025) Deputy Speaker, House of Representatives (2013–2016) Member, House of Representatives, Lanao del Sur 2nd District (1995–1998; 2007–2016) Speaker, ARMM Regional Legislative Assembly

From 1990 to 1993, he served as Assemblyman representing the 2nd District of Lanao del Sur in the ARMM Regional Legislative Assembly. During that same period, from 1991 to 1993, he rose to become Speaker of that assembly. It was his first experience presiding over a legislative body, and a preview of what he would do again, decades later, in the Bangsamoro Parliament.

House of Representatives

Getting to Congress wasn't easy. Balindong ran for the House of Representatives in the 1987 elections but lost to Mohammad Ali Dimaporo.

He kept at it. In 1995, he won the seat for Lanao del Sur's 2nd District, representing his constituency in the 10th Congress. He served from June 30, 1995, to June 30, 1998, with Mohammad Ali Dimaporo as his predecessor and Benasing Macarambon, Jr., as his successor.

After a gap, he ran again in 2007 and won, this time serving across three consecutive congresses: the 14th, 15th, and 16th. His second run in Congress lasted from June 30, 2007, to June 30, 2016, succeeding Benasing Macarambon, Jr., and followed by Mauyag Papandayan, Jr.

In 2013, midway through his final congressional term, he was elevated to Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives, a position he held under President Benigno Aquino III until 2016.

It was during these years in Congress that Balindong produced some of his most lasting legislative work.

He authored Republic Act No. 9997, which established the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos in 2009. The law gave Muslim Filipinos a dedicated government body to address their welfare, rights, and integration into national life.

He also authored the Integrated History Act of 2016, or Republic Act No. 10908, which required the inclusion of Moro and indigenous peoples' history in the national history curriculum. The law was a direct challenge to the way Philippine education had long sidelined or erased Bangsamoro perspectives from the national story.

He filed House Bill 144, which proposed banning the use of religious identifiers such as "Muslim" or "Christian" when describing crime suspects in news reporting, arguing that such labeling fed harmful stereotypes and deepened communal divisions.

(1991–1993) Assemblyman, ARMM 2nd District, Lanao del Sur (1990–1993) Delegate, 1971 Philippine Constitutional Convention

Spouse

Jamela Malawani Alonto (m. April 28, 1968)

Children

8, including Yasser Balindong

Fraternity

Mu Kappa Phi Exclusive Law Fraternity

Notability

First Speaker of the Bangsamoro Parliament; author of the law creating the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos; champion of Bangsamoro political rights across five decades of public service

Known For

Authoring Republic Act No. 9997 (National Commission on Muslim Filipinos Act); Republic Act No. 10908 (Integrated History Act of 2016); advocacy for the Bangsamoro Organic Law; legal counsel for the MNLF

Pull Quote

"A dreamer for peace, defender of Bangsamoro."

And throughout his time in Congress, he was one of the loudest voices pushing for the Bangsamoro Basic Law, the legislative framework that would eventually take shape as the Bangsamoro Organic Law of 2018, establishing the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

Consultative Committee on Charter Change

In 2018, President Rodrigo Duterte appointed Balindong to the 25-member Consultative Committee to Review the 1987 Philippine Constitution, convened under Executive Order No. 10.

The committee was composed of former government officials, veteran lawyers, and academics, all tasked with drafting a federal constitution. Balindong's inclusion reflected his standing as one of the country's most experienced Muslim Filipino statesmen.

Bangsamoro Parliament

In 2019, Balindong joined the Bangsamoro Transition Authority (BTA), the interim body that constituted the first Bangsamoro Parliament.

On March 29, 2019, he was elected Speaker of the BTA Parliament, having been nominated by Mohagher Iqbal. He was nominated by the Bangsamoro Transition Authority itself and appointed under President Duterte, with Chief Minister Murad Ebrahim heading the executive side of the new government.

In September 2022, he was reelected to the speakership, this time with Abdulraof Macacua serving as an additional Chief Minister and under the appointment of President Bongbong Marcos.

He held the speakership until his death on October 2, 2025, having served in the role for over six years. He was succeeded by Mohammad Yacob.

INSTITUTIONAL CONTRIBUTIONS

Balindong's contribution to Philippine institutions runs across three distinct levels.

At the national level, his landmark legislation gave Muslim Filipinos a formal government commission (the NCMF), rewrote how Philippine history is taught, and pushed for constitutional and legislative reforms that recognized Bangsamoro political identity.

At the regional level, he helped shape the governance architecture of the ARMM through his time as ARMM Assemblyman and Regional Speaker, years before BARMM existed.

At the transitional level, he became the face of the Bangsamoro Parliament's opening chapter, presiding over its earliest sessions as a body that represented the culmination of decades of peace negotiations.

His legal work for the MNLF in the earlier part of his career also placed him at the intersection of armed struggle and peaceful advocacy, navigating a moment in Bangsamoro history when both were happening simultaneously.

LEGACY

Pangalian Balindong lived long enough to see the parliament his people had long demanded finally come to life, and he got to preside over it.

That alone would have been enough. But his legacy is also rooted in the quieter, harder work of legislation: the education act, the Muslim Filipinos commission, the anti-stereotyping bill, the years of pushing for the Bangsamoro Organic Law. These were not symbolic gestures. They were structural changes to how the Philippine state related to its Muslim citizens.

He was described by the Bangsamoro Information Office as "a dreamer for peace, defender of Bangsamoro," and that characterization held across the different chapters of his life, whether he was sitting as legal counsel for the MNLF, arguing on the floor of Congress, or presiding over a parliament that represented the hopes of millions.

He died at St. Luke's Medical Center in Quezon City on October 2, 2025, after an undisclosed illness. He was 85.

RECOGNITION

Balindong's standing was recognized at multiple points in his career through appointments and elections to bodies that carried significant national weight, including the 1971 Constitutional Convention, the position of Deputy Speaker of the House, and the 25-member Consultative Committee on Charter Change in 2018.

His election and reelection as Speaker of the Bangsamoro Parliament is perhaps the clearest institutional recognition of the trust placed in him by the Bangsamoro community and its political leadership.

SEE ALSO

- Bangsamoro Parliament
- Bangsamoro Transition Authority
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Moro National Liberation Front
- Lanao del Sur
- Maranao people
- Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao

REFERENCES

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CATEGORIES

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